

Recommendation Report: Proposal for a Campus Fishing Pond at Central Maine
Community College
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Executive Summary

This report explores the feasibility of constructing a stocked fishing pond at Central Maine Community College. This project will help determine whether a campus pond would provide recreational, educational, and wellness benefits for students while also staying financially realistic. Research methods included student surveys, interviews, campus observation, cost research, and academic studies on outdoor recreation. Results of the surveys and interviews suggest a strong student interest; possible classroom use and academic studies show multiple wellness benefits. Based on my research and findings, this report recommends that CMCC should pursue a phased development to a small to medium sized campus fishing pond.

Introduction

Central Maine Community College has an opportunity to improve student life through the creation of a stocked fishing pond on campus. Colleges around the world have been investing in increasing numbers in outdoor recreation spaces to improve student satisfaction, retention, and wellness. A fishing pond would create a unique campus feature while also supporting educational programs such as the schools Conservation Law Enforcement, Business and environmental studies. This report will examine whether a pond project would be practical and beneficial for CMCC.

Background

Many college campuses provide recreational amenities like trails, fitness centers and outdoor gather spaces. A small but growing subset of these colleges offering some form of fishing pond or water-based outdoor recreation area. It is also noted that there has been an increase in competition fishing teams being created by colleges. This provides opportunities for team building and provides students with opportunities for academic scholarships for their success or skills in competition.

CMCC is located in Maine, which has a rich history in outdoor recreation and fishing. Because of this a campus pond may align well with student interests and local values while also providing an opportunity for students who may not have spent their whole lives in Maine a chance at exploring some of the natural wonder and history our state provides.

The campus currently contains walking trails and access to Lake Auburn from the shore. Unfortunately, that section of the lake is closed to any form of recreation due to the drinking water intake plant that is directly next to the campus. After a survey of the campus, I have identified 3 possible locations for a small to medium pond to be constructed. This would provide access to water recreation and expand upon the current outdoor infrastructure the campus already provides.

Research Methods

Research for this report included several methods:

Student Survey

I created a google forms survey and asked CMCC students on campus or in class discord groups to fill it out. The survey included questions about student interest in a stocked fishing pond on campus, should the public have access, and should it be used for classes? Eighteen students responded, providing a small but useful sample of campus opinion. (Maxim, 2026)

Bates Student Survey

I spent some time on Bates College campus exploring and walking around the pond they have on campus. I stopped and surveyed some students and asked what the pond on campus provides to them as students. Would they participate in fishing if the pond was stocked and gear was available and a short statement about their experience with the pond on campus. (Maxim, 2026)

Local Resident Bus Survey

While riding the public bus to school I surveyed a bus riders and asked if there was an interest in visiting/ using a stocked pond on CMCC campus, would public bus access make it more likely to visit a fishing pond at CMCC and what would interest them the most about a community fishing pond. (Maxim, 2026)

Site Observation

I walked to the CMCC campus and identified three possible pond locations, parking access, trail access, and nearby infrastructure. (Maxim, 2026)

Secondary Research

I reviewed Academic articles regarding studies done on the benefits of outdoor recreation for college students. State of Maine .gov websites with permit and legal information on the requirements of starting and maintaining a stocked pond. I also browsed multiple websites on pond construction and landscaping to find out exactly what would be needed for equipment to run and maintain a pond and the general cost of construction and materials as well as upkeep and maintenance.

Analysis and Evaluation

Student Interest

Results from student surveys indicate a strong interest in a campus fishing pond. 77% of students surveyed responded that they would utilize a stocked fishing pond on campus. (Maxim, 2026)

94.4% of responders of the survey said they believed there would be a benefit to use of the pond in classes/school curriculum. (Maxim, 2026)

Bates College Student Interview

Interviewing students on a college campus with a pond, brought good insight into some of the possible benefits to mental health and wellness for students with access to a pond. students where surveyed on possible benefits of a pond on campus and what they feel or use it for. (Maxim, 2026)

100% of surveyed students said the pond provided stress relief / relaxation as well as a place to connect with nature. 66.7% reported socializing as well as exercising / walking as a benefit. (Maxim, 2026)

Educational Value

A campus fishing pond would provide educational benefits on top of a space for recreation. Survey responses show student interest and support in the idea of using the pond for academic purposes.

Research supports this type of use. According to the peer reviewed article Benefits of Campus Outdoor Recreation Programs, recreation spaces provide opportunities to “support academic programs directly” The authors writes "For colleges and universities, these benefits include positive effects on student recruitment, retention, and satisfaction and the opportunity for recreation programs to support academic programs directly." Some of the key points she brings up in the paper is the correlation between outdoor academic programs and increased academic success, “participation correlates with better grades, persistence, and overall performance.” (Benefits of campus outdoor recreation programs, n.d.)

An additional study also supports improved student wellbeing and academic outcomes tied to outdoor recreation participation (Outdoor recreation and college student wellbeing study, 2021).

Because of these factors, the basic pond and full recreation pond options offer a clear education advantages vs the no pond option that provides none.

Wellness and Student Experience

A campus fishing pond would provide wellness benefits and improve the overall student experience. Survey responses and student feedback suggest that many students are interested in having a quiet outdoor space to relax and socialize or take a break between classes.

Research strongly supports the connection between outdoor recreation and mental health. According to the peer reviewed article Benefits of Campus Outdoor Recreation Programs, participation in outdoor activities is associated with “lower levels of stress and anxiety” as well as improved mental and physical health. The authors also note that students involved in recreation experience “better and more numerous social connections.” (Benefits of campus outdoor recreation programs, n.d.)

This means a campus pond could serve as more than just a recreational feature. It would provide a space where students can reduce stress, build friendships, and feel more connected to campus life. This could be especially beneficial for CMCC where many students commute and may not spend time on campus outside of classes.

Because of these factors, both pond options provide clear wellness and student experience benefits, while the no pond option does not improve current conditions.

Cost and Feasibility

Cost is one of the most important factors when evaluating whether a campus pond is a realistic project. Research on homeguide.com and multiple landscaping business shows that building a small to medium sized pond would require an estimated investment between \$30,000 and \$60,000 depending on size, soil conditions, drainage and additional features (HomeGuide, n.d.; KS Land & Pond, n.d.).

Conclusion

Central Maine Community College currently lacks accessible water based recreation despite its location and large outdoor area on campus. A fishing and recreating pond on campus would provide significant benefits including improved student wellness, increased opportunities for social connection and support for academic programs such as the schools conservation law program.

Research and survey data indicate a strong interest in a pond for outdoor recreation on campus while cost analysis shows that a smaller, phased approach is financially realistic.

Based on these findings, CMCC should move forward with the planning and development of a campus fishing pond. This project shows a practical investment in the student experience, campus engagement and long term community value.